THE FEE & MARGIN PLAYBOOK

What the marketplace actually takes — and how to price so you never lose.

Every platform quotes one fee and charges another. This is what you really keep per sale in 2026, platform by platform, the hidden costs nobody warns you about, when the money actually lands, and the rule that keeps you from flipping at a loss.

Updated Nov 2026 US sellers ~20 min read

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01

Your profit is a lie (until you subtract fees)

You buy a hoodie for $168, sell it for $240, and tell yourself you made $72. You didn't. After the platform's cut, payment processing, and the label you paid for, your real take-home is closer to $45 — and if you listed it on the wrong platform, under $10.

> **The sellers who last aren't the ones with the best eye. They're the ones who know their real number before they buy.**

Fees moved a lot in the last two years — Mercari shifted its cut back to sellers, Depop and Vinted dropped seller fees, Whatnot layered commission on top of processing. Most "fee guides" online still quote 2022 numbers. Here's where it actually stands, and how to price around it.

02

What you keep on a $50 sale

All-in seller cost including payment processing, on a $50 item. Rounded; confirm current rates on each platform's fee page before you price.

PLATFORM	SELLER CUT	FEE ON $50	YOU KEEP
Vinted	0% seller fee	-$0.00	$50.00
Depop	~3.3% + $0.45 processing	-$2.10	$47.90
Mercari	10% commission	-$5.00	$45.00
Etsy	~9.5% + $0.45	-$5.20	$44.80
Whatnot	~8% + 2.9% + $0.30	-$5.75	$44.25
StockX	~9% + 3% (tiered)	-$6.00	$44.00
Grailed	~9% + 3.5% + $0.49	-$6.75	$43.25
eBay	~13.6% + $0.40	-$7.20	$42.80
Amazon	~15% referral	-$7.50	$42.50
GOAT	~9.5% + $5 flat	-$9.75	$40.25
Poshmark	20% (≥$15)	-$10.00	$40.00

Read it right: flat fees (eBay's $0.40, GOAT's $5) barely register on expensive items but gut cheap ones. A % fee hurts the same at every price. That difference is the whole game — see the next two sections.

03

How fees scale with price

The *effective* fee rate changes with price because of flat fees. The same platform can be your cheapest option on a $500 item and your most expensive on a $15 one. This is why "what's the cheapest platform?" has no single answer.

Effective all-in fee as a % of sale price, at four price points.

PLATFORM	$15 ITEM	$50 ITEM	$150 ITEM	$500 ITEM
Poshmark	$2.95 flat	20.0%	20.0%	20.0%
eBay	16.3%	14.4%	13.9%	13.7%
Depop	6.3%	4.2%	3.6%	3.4%
GOAT	42.8%	19.5%	12.8%	10.5%
Whatnot	13.0%	11.5%	11.1%	10.9%

The lesson: never sell a cheap item somewhere with a big flat fee — GOAT takes **43%** of a $15 sale. And Poshmark's flat $2.95 under $15 (the 20% only kicks in at $15+) actually makes it one of the *best* places for sub-$15 items. Match the platform to the price, not just the category.

04

The full fee matrix

Keep this one bookmarked. It's exactly what lands in your pocket — after all fees and processing — at four price points, every major platform. Before you list anything, glance at the column for its price.

Dollars you keep after all-in fees. Shipping not included. Rounded estimates, US, Nov 2026.

PLATFORM	KEEP ON $15	ON $50	ON $150	ON $500
Vinted	$15.00	$50.00	$150.00	$500.00

PLATFORM	KEEP ON $15	ON $50	ON $150	ON $500
Depop	$14.06	$47.90	$144.60	$483.05
Mercari	$13.50	$45.00	$135.00	$450.00
Etsy	$13.13	$44.80	$135.30	$452.05
Whatnot	$13.07	$44.25	$133.35	$445.20
StockX	$13.20	$44.00	$132.00	$440.00
Grailed	$12.64	$43.26	$130.77	$437.06
eBay	$12.56	$42.80	$129.20	$431.60
Amazon	$12.75	$42.50	$127.50	$425.00
Poshmark	$12.05	$40.00	$120.00	$400.00
GOAT	$8.58	$40.25	$130.75	$447.50

Notice how the ranking *reshuffles* across columns. GOAT is dead last on a $15 item and near the top on a $500 one. Poshmark is fine when small, punishing when big. There is no single "best platform" — only the best platform *for this item at this price.*

05

The same hoodie, three platforms

A $168 Supreme hoodie, sold for $240, $14 shipping label you cover. Where you list it swings your profit by **4×**.

Grailed best

$44.80

Sold	$240.00
Fees	-$13.20
Shipping	-$14.00
Cost	-$168.00

+27% ROI

eBay

$39.08

Sold	$240.00
Fees	-$18.92
Shipping	-$14.00
Cost	-$168.00

+23% ROI

Poshmark worst

$10.00

Sold	$240.00
Fees	-$48.00
Shipping	$0.00*
Cost	-$168.00

+6% ROI

*Poshmark buyers pay shipping, which softens the 20% a little — but on a high-ticket item the cut still wrecks you. Same work, same product, **$34.80 more profit** just from listing in the right place.

06

Platform-by-platform: the real deal

Fees are only half the story. Each platform has a quirk that costs or saves you money. Here's what matters per place.

eBay

`~13.6% + $0.40 / order`

Best for: **almost anything** — biggest buyer base, electronics, cards, sneakers, tickets.

WATCH **Promoted Listings** are optional ads that take an extra 2–20%+ on top of fees. Easy to leave on by accident.

GOOD On a refund, eBay returns the **percentage** fee but keeps the $0.40. A Store subscription lowers your rate if you sell volume.

Poshmark

`$2.95 under $15 · 20% at $15+`

Best for: **women's clothing, shoes, accessories** under ~$40, and cheap items.

GOOD Buyer pays shipping, and the flat $2.95 under $15 beats everyone on cheap items.

WATCH That 20% is savage on anything over ~$50. "Offer to Likers" discounts (and shared shipping) cut your margin further.

Mercari

`10% commission`

Best for: **general used goods, home, electronics, toys** — volume, not luxury.

GOOD Flat 10%, no listing fees, payment processing now sits on the buyer's side.

WATCH "Promote" and Smart Offers quietly auto-discount your item to buyers who liked it — you eat that.

Depop & Vinted

`~0% seller fee`

Best for: **Gen-Z fashion, vintage, streetwear, cheap clothing volume.**

GOOD Lowest seller costs anywhere — both dropped seller fees (buyers now pay). Depop still charges ~3.3% processing.

WATCH Buyer-paid fees make your listing look pricier at checkout, which can slow sales. Depop "Boosted" listings cost ~8–12%.

StockX & GOAT

`~9–15% all-in (tiered)`

Best for: **deadstock sneakers, hype, sealed goods** — authentication builds buyer trust.

GOOD Buyers trust the authentication, so they pay more. Your fee % drops as you hit higher seller levels.

WATCH You ship to them first (adds days + a label), payouts can hold, and GOAT's flat fees murder cheap pairs.

Grailed

`~9% + 3.5% + $0.49`

Best for: **men's designer, archive, streetwear** — a buyer base that knows the brands.

GOOD Low fees + the right audience = top net on designer pieces. Cheaper than eBay for the same item.

WATCH Smaller audience and slower sales than eBay — you trade speed for margin.

Whatnot

`~8% + 2.9% + $0.30`

Best for: **trading cards, collectibles, toys** sold live.

GOOD Live auctions create urgency and often push prices above "market" — fees pay for themselves.

WATCH You have to actually go live and host. It's a performance, not a passive listing.

Facebook / Local

`Free (local, cash)`

Best for: **furniture, electronics, big-ticket, bulky items.**

GOOD Zero fees on local cash deals — keep 100%. Unbeatable on a $700 console or a couch.

WATCH No buyer protection, no-shows, lowballers, and meet-up hassle. Shipped FB orders do carry a ~5% fee.

07

The hidden costs that quietly eat you

Fees are the obvious cut. These are the ones that don't show up in the headline rate but show up in your bank account.

- **Promoted / boosted listings.** eBay Promoted, Depop Boost, Poshmark & Mercari promote — all take an *extra* cut on top of fees, often 2–12%+. Turn them on deliberately, not by default.
- **Shipping you eat.** A $9 label on a $35 item is 26% gone before any fee. Know for each platform whether you or the buyer pays, and price accordingly.
- **Returns & refunds.** Some platforms refund your fees on a return, some don't. You may also eat return shipping and get an item back in worse condition. Build a small return rate into your pricing.
- **Offers & coupons.** "Accept offer," "offer to likers," auto-coupons — every one is a discount off *your* margin, not the platform's.
- **Crosslisting tools & supplies.** Apps like Vendoo or List Perfectly run $10–40/mo. Poly mailers, boxes, tape, thermal labels, ink — all real costs. All deductible (see Guide 02).

Every one of these is a line you should be logging in the tracker. Untracked costs don't just hurt your margin — they become income you pay tax on.

08

When you actually get paid

Margin isn't the only thing that matters — so does *cash flow.* If your money is locked up for two weeks, you can't buy the next flip. Here's roughly when funds free up and reach your bank.

Typical timing. New accounts, disputes, and high-value items hold longer.

PLATFORM	FUNDS RELEASE	TO YOUR BANK
Facebook / Local	Instantly (cash in hand)	Same day
Depop / Vinted	Around when buyer confirms	1–3 days
eBay	~1–2 days after delivery*	1–3 days
Poshmark	After delivery + accept (or 3 days)	1–3 days

PLATFORM	FUNDS RELEASE	TO YOUR BANK
Mercari	After buyer rates / 3 days post-delivery	~5 days
Whatnot	After delivery confirmed	1–5 days
StockX / GOAT	After it ships in + passes authentication	5–12+ days

*New eBay sellers can have payouts held up to **21 days** until they build a track record. If you're reinvesting fast, lean on the quick-paying platforms and keep a small cash buffer so a hold never stops you from buying.

09

When your fees drop with volume

The headline rates aren't fixed forever. As you scale, some platforms quietly get cheaper — and knowing the break points keeps you from overpaying.

- **eBay Store subscription.** Once you're listing steadily (roughly 50+ items/month), a Store plan ($4.99–$59.95/mo) cuts your final value fee and hands you hundreds of free listings. Past a certain volume it pays for itself several times over.
- **StockX & GOAT seller levels.** Both lower your transaction % as your lifetime sales climb. A brand-new StockX seller pays the top rate; a high-volume one pays noticeably less on every sale.
- **Flat 10–20% platforms (Mercari, Poshmark).** No real volume discount — the rate is the rate. Scale here comes from speed and quantity, not cheaper fees.

The takeaway: if one platform is becoming your main channel, check whether a subscription or seller tier would lower your rate before you do another month at full price.

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The rule that stops you selling at a loss

Before you buy anything to flip, run this. It gives you the **lowest price you can accept** and still hit your target profit — so you never get talked down into a bad deal.

MINIMUM LIST PRICE

```
( your cost + shipping + target profit ) ÷ ( 1 - fee% )
```

Example: a sneaker cost you $65, $8 to ship, you want at least $25 profit, selling on eBay (≈14% all-in). Minimum = ($65 + $8 + $25) ÷ 0.86 = $114. List below that and you're working for free.

Faster rule of thumb: on a 10–14% fee platform you keep roughly **85¢ of every dollar**, so to cover cost you need to sell for at least **cost ÷ 0.85** — and that's just break-even, before a cent of profit.

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Break-even multipliers

The fast version of the formula. To actually **pocket 50% of your cost as profit** after fees, sell at roughly this multiple of what you paid. (Shipping not included — add it on top.)

PLATFORM	JUST BREAK EVEN	POCKET 50% PROFIT
Vinted / Depop	1.05×	1.6×
Mercari / Grailed	1.15×	1.7×
eBay / Amazon	1.18×	1.8×
Poshmark	1.25×	1.9×

In plain words: on eBay, a $50 pickup needs to sell for about $90 to clear 50% profit after fees. On Poshmark, closer to $95. If you can't realistically sell it for that, it's not a flip — it's a donation.

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A real month, fully costed

Here's why "I did $2,000 in sales" and "I made $2,000" are completely different sentences. A part-time reseller moving $2,000 of product in a month, costed honestly:

Gross sales	$2,000.00

Cost of the items sold (COGS)	-$900.00
Platform fees **(~13% blended)**	-$260.00
Shipping labels you covered	-$150.00
Mailers, boxes, tape, labels	-$45.00
Crosslisting app	-$20.00
Real take-home profit	**$625.00**

$2,000 of sales → **about $625** actually kept. That's a healthy ~31% margin — but only if you tracked all of it. Miss the $215 in fees and supplies at tax time and you'll pay income tax on money you never kept. (Sourcing mileage is deductible too, on top of this — Guide 02.) This is the entire reason the tracker exists.

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Where to list what

Cheapest fees aren't always most profit — the right buyers matter more. Fee-adjusted, here's where each category tends to net the most.

Sneakers & hype authentication + buyer trust pays off	`StockX / GOAT / eBay`
Streetwear & designer low fees, right audience	`Grailed / Depop`
Everyday clothing volume game, keep fees low	`Vinted / Mercari`
Electronics & big-ticket avoid the % cut entirely	`Facebook / Local`
Trading cards & collectibles live-sell premium	`Whatnot / eBay`
Tickets fees eat margin — price for them	`eBay / StubHub`

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Sales tax: what you actually pay

Good news first: in almost every US state, the **marketplace collects and remits sales tax for you** (it's called marketplace facilitator law). The buyer pays it at checkout, the platform sends it to the state. It is *not* a cost that comes out of your pocket, and it's not your profit.

What you **do** owe is **income tax on your profit** — sale price minus what you paid minus your fees and expenses. That's a completely different thing, and it's where most resellers overpay by not tracking their costs. Platforms may send you a `1099-K`; as of 2025–26 the federal reporting threshold is back up to **$20,000 and 200+ transactions**, though some states are lower — and the threshold only affects *reporting*, not whether you owe.

This is the one that costs people the most, so it gets its own guide → **Guide 02: Reseller Tax & Deductions.**

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Margin rules worth tattooing on your arm

- **Aim for 50%+ ROI, not a fixed dollar amount.** Flipping $65 into $100 beats flipping $600 into $650 — same $35, far less cash at risk and faster to repeat.
- **Cheap items hide fees.** A $12 sale can lose 20%+ to flat fees alone. Bundle small items, or sell them where flat fees are low.
- **Shipping is a cost, not an afterthought.** A $9 label turns a "profit" into a loss on anything under ~$40. Price it in or make the buyer pay.
- **Tied-up cash is real.** Three items unsold for 60 days is money you can't reinvest. Track days-to-sell, not just profit.
- **Track every fee the day it happens.** At tax time, every fee you logged is a deduction. Every one you forgot is profit you'll pay tax on.
- **Speed beats a few extra dollars.** A fast, certain sale at 40% ROI usually beats holding for a "maybe" 60%. Cash that moves compounds.

That fifth rule is why this kit comes with a tracker — fees you don't record become taxable income you didn't actually keep.

Keep this honest. Marketplace fees, payout timing, and tax thresholds change often and vary by seller level, category, item price, promotions, and state — the numbers here are current-as-of estimates for US sellers, not quotes. Always confirm the live rate on each platform's official fee page before you price an item. Nothing here is financial or tax advice; for your specific situation, talk to a qualified tax professional.